

QED SHANKAR AIYAR

Politics of Loyalty



In a sense the presidential poll could well be the first dry run of E-2009. We say E-2009 but it could well be E-2008 or even E-2007. Lack of governance and absence of delivery will make it tougher for parties to garner votes. And no amount of grandstanding about "inclusive growth" will help unless the *aam aadmi* sees evidence of intent on the ground. Ergo, barring a miracle, the NDA and the UPA together are unlikely to cross the 250 mark in a House of 543. As in any market, new players will seize the initiative, leaving the Big 2 nostalgic of a past that was and bemoaning a future that will be. The ubiquitous phrase in every post-poll analysis will be that mythical factor called "anti-incumbency", the fig leaf that parties and politicians use to cover their failure to regain power.

As private India forges ahead into the 21st century, governance is still stuck in the 19th century. Arguably, politics is among the largest private enterprises in India. The battle for a share of the mind space of nearly 700 million people, spread across 30 states, fought among 230 parties, should make politics among the most competitive arenas of individual enterprise. Yet, where it matters and when it matters, merit doesn't seem to matter.

Parties and politicians often lament that good people don't enter politics. Why would anyone enter a field where there is no real role for merit? Is Pratibha Patil, for instance, the best candidate that the Congress, its allies and the ostensibly conscientious Left could choose from their bag? Obviously, obsequious loyalty overrules everything else. Sometimes merit converges with loyalty but generally loyalty is the first, second and the third condition. Look at the composition of the Union Cabinet. Can the UPA honestly claim it has the best players on the ground? It is not very different with the Opposition parties either. Sycophancy seems to be the ideology of the day.

No private enterprise anywhere has fought competition with loyalty and survived. Parties need to recognise that relegation of merit for loyalty is only tarring their worsening image further. And it is only merit that can deliver governance and thus, power. Politics is finally a battle of ideas. Loyalty is not an idea, it is a mindset defined by fear. New ideas cannot bloom in the cesspool of fear that loyalty breeds in. Ideas require courage and allegiance to merit. Political parties must recognise this truth if they want to stay in orbit.



SAURABH SINGH

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"Manmohan Singh is very cool"

ACTOR AND SINGER RAKHI SAWANT SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about marriage, movies and her childhood

Q. There's only one superwoman in India, Sonia Gandhi. Manmohan Singh and Baba Ramdev are supermen.

A. Our prime minister is not a superman because he's very cool. I like Baba Ramdev for his yoga teachings.

Q. I heard you've got married.

A. The media has nothing else to do except publish rumours. I'll never marry secretly.

Q. Will you marry your boyfriend Abhishek?

A. I can't marry now because I am a manglik. I may marry in 2011-12. Even Amitabh Bachchan and Himesh Reshammiya wear many stones. I'm young and beautiful. After marriage, a romance may change to stress.

Q. You're not getting films because you do not have film background.

A. But people love me. I work in reality shows and in item numbers. I'm doing the film *Budha Mar Gaya*.

Q. You act well, sing and dance well. But you don't get a film with a good director like Karan Johar.

A. I'm doing small roles. Karan Johar will give me an opportunity one day.

Q. Big stars like Kareena Kapoor, Bipasha Basu also do item numbers.

A. I'm an item girl. My style has its own magic. I dance like acid.

Q. These days stars use plastic surgery.

A. Everyone wants to look glamorous. If science can change our incompleteness then why shouldn't we try it?

Q. Who is your competitor? Mallika Sherawat or Shilpa Shetty?

A. No one is my competitor. Why do you compare Mallika Sherawat with me?

Q. How will you get big roles without a godfather?

A. The media is my godfather. People love me. I am different from Rani Mukherjee, Kareena, Vidya Balan.

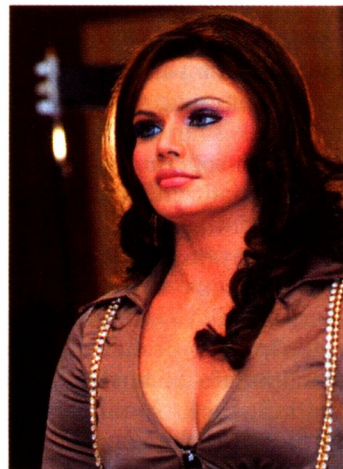
Q. Was your childhood full of problems.

A. My childhood was full of sorrow. My family was very conservative. I tried to commit suicide once. My parents wanted a traditional girl but I wanted my freedom.

Q. What is your dream?

A. To be a celebrity. I want to earn for the poor child. I studied in a municipal school so I know the problems.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday



Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>

